(d) Very few alpha particles returned back (back scattered) –that is, deflected back by 180°

In Figure 9.10 (c), the dotted points are the alpha scattering experiment data points obtained by Geiger and Marsden and the solid curve is the prediction from Rutherford's nuclear model. It is observed that the Rutherford's nuclear model is in good agreement with the experimental data.

Conclusion made by Rutherford based on the above observation

From the experimental observations, Rutherford proposed that an atom has a lot of empty space and contains a tiny matter at its centre known as nucleus whose size is of the order of 10^{-14}m. The nucleus is positively charged and most of the mass of the atom is concentrated in the nucleus. The nucleus is surrounded by negatively charged electrons. Since static charge distribution cannot be in a stable equilibrium, he suggested that the electrons are not at rest and they revolve around the nucleus in circular orbits like planets revolving around the sun.

(a) Distance of closest approach

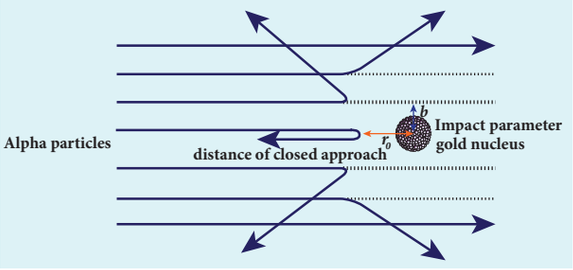


Figure 9.11 Distance of closest approach and impact parameter

When an alpha particle moves straight towards the nucleus, it reaches a point where it comes to rest momentarily and returns back as shown in Figure 9.11. **The minimum distance between the centre of the nucleus and the alpha particle just before it gets reflected back through 180° is defined as the distance of closest approach r_0 (also known as contact distance)**. At this distance, all the kinetic energy of the alpha particle will be converted into electrostatic potential energy (Refer unit 1, volume 1 of +2 physics text book).

$$\frac{1}{2}m\upsilon_0^{\,2} = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{(2e)(Ze)}{r_0}$$

$$\Rightarrow r_0 = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{2Ze^2}{\left(\frac{1}{2}m\upsilon_0^2\right)} = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{2Ze^2}{E_k}$$

where E_k is the kinetic energy of the alpha particle.This is used to estimate the size of the nucleus but size of the nucleus is always lesser than the distance of closest approach. Further, Rutherford calculated the radius of the nucleus for different nuclei and found that it ranges from 10^{-14} m to 10^{-15} m.

(b) Impact parameter

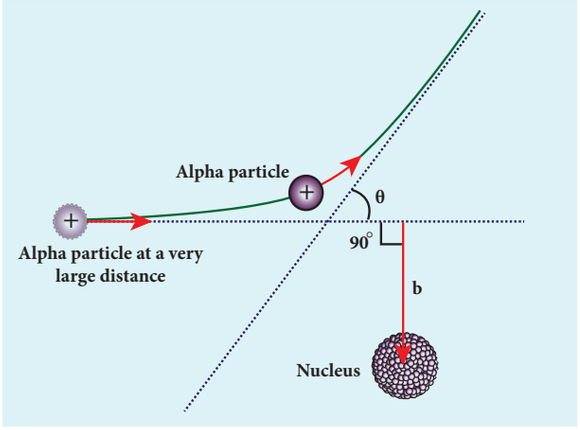


Figure 9.12 Impact parameter

The impact parameter (b) (see Figure 9.12) **is defined as the perpendicular distance between the centre of the gold nucleus and the direction of velocity vector of alpha particle when it is at a large distance**. The

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